



SongGhost

The Prompt Book

How to tell Rudy what your song is about



What's in here

Read the first four chapters once. Then live in the recipes.

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CHAPTER 1

Hello. I'm Rudy.

The whole book in one idea: what you type changes everything.



I write songs for people who have something to say and no idea how to say it in a song.

You already know how this works. You open SongGhost, you type what your song is about, and I write it. Verses. A chorus. The little shouted bits in brackets. Cover art, if you want it.

Here is the part nobody tells you.

What you type changes everything. Two people can ask me for a song about losing their dad. One gets something that could be about anyone's dad. One gets something that makes their family cry. The difference is not luck. It is not a better version of me. It is about forty extra words in the box.

This book is those forty words.

It is free. There is no catch, and nothing to buy at the end. I would just rather you make something good, because people who make something good come back and make another one.

How to use this book

Read the first part once. It is short, and it is the part that actually changes your songs.

Then flip to your genre and steal the recipe. Every genre gets the same two pages: a weak prompt, a strong one, and why the second one works. Swap in your own details and go.

You do not have to read it in order. Nobody is checking.

A promise about words. I will not use a music word without telling you what it means. If I say *hook*, I will tell you a hook is the bit people sing back at you. If I slip up, that is my fault, not yours.

CHAPTER 2

Why your first song came back flat

It is almost never the song's fault. It is the forty words you did not type.



Let me guess what you typed.

a song about my mom

It is a fine thing to type. It is also almost nothing to work with.

Think about what I actually know from that. You have a mom. That is it. I do not know her name. I do not know if she is alive. I do not know if you are grateful or angry or both at once.

So I do what anyone does with no information. I write the average version. I reach for the things that are true of most moms — she was always there, she gave up so much, she is my rock. None of it is wrong. None of it is *yours* either.

That is the flat feeling. The song is about a mother. It is not about **your** mother.

The good news

I am built to follow your story, not to make one up.

The rules I write by are strict about this. When you give me a real detail, I am supposed to use it and build around it. When you give me nothing, I am not allowed to just leave a hole, so I fill it with the most ordinary thing that fits. Vague in, average out. That is not me being lazy. That is me having nothing of yours to hold onto.

Hand me one true thing and I will build the whole song on it.

One example, quickly

Same song. Same mom. Here is what happens when you give me something to work with.

My mom's name is Reyna. She cut hair in our kitchen for thirty years. The house always smelled like perm solution and coffee. She died in April. I keep her scissors in my glovebox and I don't know why.

Now I have a name. A room. A smell. A time. And one strange, specific, completely true thing — the scissors in the glovebox — that no one else on earth would have handed me.

I do not have to invent anything. I just have to not get in the way.

That is the whole book, really. The rest is showing you how to do that on purpose, and how to steer the sound while you are at it.

CHAPTER 3

The five things every good prompt has

Three of these will already put you ahead of nearly everyone.



You do not need all five every time. Three will already put you ahead of almost everyone. But this is the whole list, in the order I would add them.

1. One true thing

Give me a detail you could not have looked up.

A name. A street. A smell. A time on a clock. The dumb object you kept.

This matters more than everything else on this list combined. A real detail is proof. It tells me this song belongs to one person, and it gives me something solid to build lines around. Generic words give me nothing to hold.

INSTEAD OF	TRY
my grandma	my grandma Essie, who kept butterscotch in her coat
we broke up	she left on a Tuesday and took the good pan
my hometown	Route 9, past the closed Dairy Queen

You are not writing the song here. You are handing me the raw material. Ugly notes are fine. I will make them pretty.

2. Who is talking, and who they are talking to

Say who "I" is and who "you" is.

Most flat songs are flat because nobody is home in them. If I do not know who is speaking, I write a narrator with no face.

Try one line like:

This is me talking to my brother, who is not speaking to me right now.

Now every line has a direction to travel. It changes what the chorus can even say.

3. What the song should *do*

A song has a job. Tell me the job.

Is this an apology? A thank-you? A warning? Is it for a first dance at a wedding, or for you alone in the car?

Songs that do one job clearly are the ones that land. Songs that try to do all of it end up doing none of it.

I want this played at her retirement party. It should be funny for most of it, then get you right at the end.

That single sentence tells me the tone, the room, the shape and where to put the punch.

4. The room

Say a style word on purpose, or I will pick for you.

This is the one people miss, and it is the easiest win in the whole book.

Every genre I write has smaller rooms inside it. Country has a honky-tonk bar and it has a stadium. Gospel has a full choir and it has one person and a piano. Same genre. Completely different songs.

I listen for particular words to decide which room you meant. Say **honky-tonk** and you get the bar. Say **arena** and you get the stadium. Say neither and I pick the default, which may not be what you pictured.

Every genre chapter in this book lists those words. They are not magic and they are not secret. They are just the words I am listening for.

5. The one picture

Pick one image and tell me to keep coming back to it.

Strong songs usually have a single thing the words keep returning to. The scissors in the glovebox. The porch light left on. The chair nobody sits in.

Give me that thing, and say you want it to come back. It turns a list of feelings into a song with a shape.

Keep coming back to the porch light. End on it.

The shape, all together

You do not have to write it neatly. This is enough:

Room: honky-tonk **True thing:** Dad's name was Roy, he fixed washing machines **Who:** me, to my dad, who has dementia and thinks I'm his brother **Job:** something I could actually play for him **Picture:** his hands, and how they still know what to do

Five short lines. Under a minute to type. That is the difference between a song about a dad and a song about Roy.

CHAPTER 4

Watch me fix one

One weak prompt, rebuilt in five moves, in front of you.



Let's take a real one and rebuild it in front of you. Five moves, one at a time, so you can see each one do its job.

Here is where we start.

Start: a happy song about my wife

Nothing wrong with it. It is just empty. Watch what happens.

Move 1 — add one true thing

a happy song about my wife **Nadia, who laughs at her own jokes before she finishes them**

That one clause changes everything. Nadia is now a specific person with a specific habit. I can write lines about that habit. I could not write lines about "my wife".

Move 2 — say who is talking, and to whom

a happy song **from me to Nadia**, who laughs at her own jokes before she finishes them

Small change. Now the song has a direction. It is not *about* her from a distance. It is *to* her. Every line gets pointed at somebody.

Move 3 — give it a job

a happy song from me to Nadia, who laughs at her own jokes before she finishes them. ****It's for our tenth anniversary dinner. I want to make her cry the good way.****

Now I know the room it gets played in and what it has to achieve. "Cry the good way" is doing a lot of work — it tells me warm, not funny, and it tells me to build to something.

Move 4 — pick the room

Lovers rock. A happy song from me to Nadia, who laughs at her own jokes before she finishes them. It's for our tenth anniversary dinner. I want to make her cry the good way.

Two words at the front. Now it is a warm, slow, romantic reggae song instead of whatever I would have guessed. If you had wanted a big wedding-band moment, **first dance** would have taken you somewhere else entirely.

Move 5 — give it one picture

Lovers rock. A happy song from me to Nadia, who laughs at her own jokes before she finishes them. It's for our tenth anniversary dinner. I want to make her cry the good way. **She still keeps the receipt from our first date in her wallet. Keep coming back to that receipt.**

There it is. A song with a name in it, a direction, a job, a sound and a thing to hold onto.

Before and after, side by side

Before: a happy song about my wife

After: Lovers rock. A happy song from me to Nadia, who laughs at her own jokes before she finishes them. It's for our tenth anniversary dinner. I want to make her cry the good way. She still keeps the receipt from our first date in her wallet. Keep coming back to that receipt.

Same song idea. About sixty extra words. It took under a minute to type.

That is the whole trick, and now you have seen it done.

Your turn. Open songghost.com or the [iOS app](#) and try your own five moves before you read on. It sticks better if you do it once.

CHAPTER 5

I tested this

Both prompts, run through the real app.
Here is exactly what came back.



I did not want to just tell you this works. So I ran both prompts through SongGhost for real, on the same day, with the same settings. The only thing I changed was the words in the box.

Here is exactly what came back.

The weak one

a song about my grandma

It titled the song "**Grandma's Song**". This was the first verse.

You always kept the porch light on
Waiting up for me to come home
With cookies warm and open arms
A little laugh, your favorite song

Read that again. It is not bad writing. It is just not about anyone. Porch light, cookies, open arms. Later verses gave me tea in the morning, flowers in the window and photos on the wall.

Every one of those could belong to any grandmother who ever lived. That is the problem. I had nothing of hers, so I wrote the average.

The strong one

Singer-songwriter. My grandma Rosa taught me to make her tortillas every Sunday in her kitchen in Tucson. She always said "use your hands, not the spoon." She can't stand at the counter as long as she used to, so I bought her a wooden stool to sit on while she watches me try. I want the chorus to land on her saying that line.

It titled the song "**Use Your Hands**". Same first verse slot:

Sunday morning, Tucson sun
Grandma Rosa in the kitchen, flour on her thumbs
Apron tied, she smiles at me
"Mi niña, let's make memories"

And the chorus landed exactly where I asked it to:

She says, "Use your hands, not the spoon"
Feel the love in the dough, it'll rise with you
Every press, every turn, every heart that you've known
"Use your hands, not the spoon"
That's how you make a house a home

The stool showed up too, right where it should — in the quiet bit before the chorus lifts.

What actually changed

- **The title.** "Grandma's Song" is a placeholder. "Use Your Hands" is a song. The title came out of the detail, not out of the topic.
- **The nouns.** Tucson. Flour. An apron. A wooden stool. None of those were invented. They were all handed over.
- **The chorus did what it was told.** I asked for it to land on her line, and

it did, five times.

- **Nothing was wasted.** Every fact in that prompt shows up somewhere in the

song.

Same app. Same day. Sixty seconds more typing.

This is the only claim in this book that matters. Everything else is just showing you how to do that on purpose, in your genre.

CHAPTER 5

The 13 recipes

Find your genre. Steal the shape. Swap in your own name, place and thing. That is the whole job.



Pop

Recipe 1 of 13

Pop starts with the title — the one feeling the whole song has to deliver. Every part of the song works to make that line hit harder each time it comes back. And pop trusts one clear picture — one dress, one text you never sent — more than any big, vague feeling.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Dance-Pop	night out , club , dance floor	Lights, friends, a beat made for moving.
Pop Ballad	wedding , vows , vow renewal , first dance , in memory , in loving memory , passed away , rest in peace , funeral , celebration of life	A slow build to one big note.
Synth-Pop / Retro-Wave	synthwave , retrowave	Neon and drum machines, like a memory of the 80s.
Indie / Bedroom Pop	bedroom pop , indie , lo-fi , lofi	Close and a little fuzzy, like it was made at midnight.
Acoustic / Singer-Songwriter Pop	acoustic , singer-songwriter , singer songwriter	Just a voice and a guitar or piano. Plain and honest.
Pop-Punk / Pop-Rock Anthem	pop punk , pop-punk , quit my job	Fast, loud, and a little mad. Built for shouting along.
Latin / Tropical Pop	reggaeton , dembow , tropical , latin	A warm beat that makes you want to move.

Say nothing and you get **Dance-Pop**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a song about my grandma

Something sweet but blurry. No name, no room, no single moment — so it reaches for grandmas in general, like every other tribute song.

STRONG PROMPT

Singer-songwriter. My grandma Rosa taught me to make her tortillas every Sunday in her kitchen in Tucson. She always said "use your hands, not the spoon." She can't stand at the counter as long as she used to, so I bought her a wooden stool to sit on while she watches me try. I want the chorus to land on her saying that line.

Why it sings

- **"Singer-songwriter" picks the room.** One phrase, and you get a plain voice with a guitar instead of a wall of synths.
- **Rosa, tortillas, Tucson.** Real things it cannot invent. It has to use yours, and yours are why anyone believes the song.
- **The wooden stool.** One small object carries the story better than a list of feelings ever could.
- **You said where the chorus lands.** That gives the song an ending instead of a fade-out.

Try it: swap in your own name, place and object. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

Rock starts with the guitar riff and the room it fills, not with a fancy title. It leaves space for that guitar, so the words never crowd out the instrument that defines the whole genre. The verses carry the real story, and the chorus stays big only because that story is true.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Classic / Arena Rock	arena rock , classic rock , anthem	Big and plain, built for a crowd to sing back at you.
Alternative / Indie	alternative rock , indie rock , grunge	Quiet verse, loud chorus. A little crooked, a little inward.
Hard Rock / Punk	punk , hard rock , punk rock	Fast and loud, gone before it says sorry.

Say nothing and you get **Classic / Arena Rock**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a rock song about feeling out of place

Something loud but empty. No name, no room, no picture — so it grabs a stadium and a fist in the air, same as every other rock song.

STRONG PROMPT

Indie rock. I'm Priya, and I just moved to Cleveland for a night-shift nursing job at St. Vincent's. At 3 a.m. the break room is empty except for the vending machine humming. I still carry my badge from my old hospital in my coat pocket, and I haven't thrown it out. Keep the verses quiet and let the chorus finally get loud on the word "home."

Why it sings

- **"Indie rock" picks the room.** One phrase, and you get a quiet verse built to crack open into a loud chorus.
- **Priya, Cleveland, St. Vincent's.** Real names and places it cannot invent, so it has to use yours.
- **The old badge in her pocket.** One object says more about feeling out of place than any list of sad words.
- **You named the word the chorus lands on.** That gives the ending a target instead of a fade-out.

Try it: swap in your own name, city and object. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

Country

Recipe 3 of 13

Country wants one true thing and a turn you did not see coming. It trusts the small stuff — a name, a town, a night. If you hand it a real detail, it will build the whole song around it. If you hand it nothing, it reaches for a truck and a dirt road, and so does every other song.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Traditional / Honky-Tonk	honky-tonk , two-step , cry in your beer	A bar at closing time. Pedal steel crying under it.
Modern / Radio Country	radio country , arena , big hook	A wide chorus a crowd can sing back at you.
Americana / Alt-Country	Americana , alt-country	Quiet room, plain talk, more short story than anthem.

Say nothing and you get **Traditional / Honky-Tonk**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a sad country song about my breakup

Something smooth and forgettable. You gave it no name. No room. No picture. So it fills the gaps with tailgates and whiskey. Every other country song is using those too.

STRONG PROMPT

Honky-tonk. My wife Dana moved out in March and took the good truck. I still park on her side of the driveway without thinking about it. The dog waits by the door at 5:40 every night, because that is when she used to get home. I want the last line to land on the dog.

Why it sings

- **Honky-tonk** picks the room. One word, and the pedal steel shows up.
- **Dana, March, the good truck.** Real things. It cannot invent these, so it has to use yours — and yours are the reason anyone believes the song.
- **5:40 and the dog by the door.** That is the one picture. A song is much stronger when it keeps returning to a single image instead of listing sad feelings.
- **You told it where to land.** Asking for the last line to land on the dog gives the ending a target. Otherwise it just stops.

Try it: swap in your own name, month and object. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

R&B is aimed at one real person — a lover, an ex, a spouse. Every line should sound like something you would actually say to their face, not a slogan. It also leaves room for the voice to breathe, so a good R&B lyric never fills up every single beat.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Contemporary R&B	<i>(the default — no word needed)</i>	A real, still-figuring-it-out relationship. Messy and honest.
90s R&B	win her back , win him back , win them back , 90s , new jack swing	Warm harmonies, built to bring someone home.
2000s R&B	2000s	Sharper and more produced, built around getting caught.
Neo-Soul	who i'm becoming , who i am becoming	Loose and jazzy, about growing into yourself.
Trap-Soul / Alt-R&B	guard up	Moody and late-night, half sung, half rapped.
Quiet Storm / Slow Jam	anniversary , propose , proposal , slow jam	Slow and warm, built for two people close together.
Classic Soul / Motown	motown	Horns and harmony, a throwback that feels timeless.

Say nothing and you get **Contemporary R&B**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a song about my husband

Something warm but generic. No name, no year, no single object — so it reaches for candlelight, same as every other slow song.

STRONG PROMPT

Slow jam. My husband Marcus and I just hit our twelfth anniversary, still in the same house on Elm Street. Every night we sit on the porch swing his dad built us as a wedding gift. He still requests the same song from our first dance, even though I tease him about it. Let the bridge slow all the way down before the last chorus comes back bigger.

Why it sings

- **"Slow jam" picks the room.** One phrase, and you get slow and warm instead of a generic ballad.
- **Marcus, Elm Street, twelve years.** Real things it cannot invent, so it has to use yours.
- **The porch swing his dad built.** One object holds the marriage better than any list of loving words.
- **You told it where the bridge should go.** That gives the song a shape instead of just building forever.

Try it: swap in your own name, place and years together. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

Hip-Hop

Recipe 5 of 13

Hip-hop thinks in bars — one measure of drums plus the words that ride on top of it. The verse is the star, and it should always say something new, never repeat itself. The hook's job is smaller: it states the point, then resets the room. Any wordplay has to come from your own real details, never a borrowed line.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Boom-Bap	boom bap , boom-bap , real hip-hop	Dusty drums and a golden-era feel, built for wordplay.
Trap	trap	Hard bass and a beat that hits like a countdown.
Drill	drill , uk drill , ny drill	Dark and sliding, built for a cold, unbothered voice.
Melodic Rap	melodic rap , emo rap , sad rap , soundcloud rap	Half sung, half rapped, built for heartbreak.
Conscious / Storytelling	conscious rap , storytelling , life story , rest in peace	A verse that moves like a real story, start to finish.
West Coast / G-Funk	west coast , g-funk , g funk , lowrider	A slow, warm bounce, built for a summer afternoon.
Southern Bounce / Club	bounce music , new orleans bounce , twerk , crunk , block party	Fast and physical, built to move a whole room.

Say nothing and you get **Trap**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a rap song about my mom

Something kind but flat. No name, no place, no single moment — so it leans on a tired line, like every other tribute verse.

STRONG PROMPT

Storytelling. My mom Carmen raised me and my little sister alone in the Bronx, on Walton Avenue. She took the 5 a.m. bus to her cleaning job before either of us woke up for school. I still have the key to apartment 4B on my keychain even though we moved out years ago. Build the second verse around the sound of her key in that lock.

Why it sings

- **"Storytelling" picks the room.** One word, and the verse gets built to move like a real story.
- **Carmen, Walton Avenue, the 5 a.m. bus.** Real details it cannot invent, so it has to use yours.
- **The key to 4B.** One object says more about home than a list of thank-yous ever could.
- **You gave the second verse a job.** That gives it a target instead of more general praise.

Try it: swap in your own name, street and object you still carry. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

Afrobeats

Recipe 6 of 13

Afrobeats starts with the groove, not the sentence — the drums talk before the first word shows up. Its phrases stay short and leave gaps for a chant, a shaker, or the deep log drum sound. The hook can repeat a lot, but it still needs your real name and city under it, or it turns into an empty loop.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Afrobeats	afropop	Warm and celebration-ready, built for love and good news.
Afro-fusion / Alté	alté , alte , afro-fusion , afro fusion , afroswing	Moodier and inward, mixed feelings over a slow groove.
Amapiano-influenced (Afro-piano)	amapiano , log drum , yanos , afro house	Deep, rolling bass and wide open space for the dance floor.

Say nothing and you get **Afrobeats**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

an afrobeats song about celebrating

Something bouncy but blank. No name, no place, no single detail – so it grabs "good vibes," like every other celebration track.

STRONG PROMPT

Amapiano. My name is Amaka, and I just made regional manager after four years at the same company in Lagos. My whole crew met me on the rooftop at Sky Lounge on a Friday night to celebrate. I kept my promotion letter folded in my bag all night because I still couldn't believe it. Let the log drum carry the last minute while the crowd just chants my name.

Why it sings

- **"Amapiano" picks the room.** One word, and you get deep bass and open space instead of a plain beat.
- **Amaka, Lagos, Sky Lounge.** Real details it cannot invent, so it has to use yours.
- **The promotion letter in her bag.** One object carries the night better than "good vibes" ever could.
- **You gave the ending a job.** Telling it to let the drum carry the last minute gives the song a real end.

Try it: swap in your own name, city and object you were holding onto. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

Reggae

Recipe 7 of 13

Reggae starts with the riddim – the drum and bass groove the words have to live on. That's why the words leave the same gaps the riddim leaves. A reggae hook can repeat far more than feels normal, and it should get stronger, not weaker, each time you hear it.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Roots Reggae	roots reggae , one drop , sufferation	Steady and grounded, built for struggle, faith and thanks.
Lovers Rock	lovers rock , anniversary , romance , romantic , first dance	Sweet and close, built for one person at a time.
Dancehall	dancehall , bashment	Fast and rhythmic, built for a crowded dance floor.

Say nothing and you get **Roots Reggae**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a reggae song about hard times

Something hopeful but hazy. No name, no place, no single memory – so it reaches for "keep your head up," like every other struggle song.

STRONG PROMPT

Roots reggae. My father, Clive, left Kingston for Miami in 1998 to send money home to us. He worked two jobs and called every Sunday at noon on the payphone outside our house. I still have the record player he shipped back to me the year I turned ten. Let the last verse give thanks for everything that record player played.

Why it sings

- **"Roots reggae" picks the room.** One phrase, and you get a steady, grounded groove built for a true story.
- **Clive, Kingston, 1998.** Real details it cannot invent, so it has to use yours.
- **The record player he shipped back.** One object carries the sacrifice better than any list of hard times.
- **You told it where to give thanks.** That gives the last verse a job instead of just trailing off.

Try it: swap in your own name, place and object that made the trip. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

A gospel song picks a direction first. Is it telling people what God did? Is it speaking straight to God? Or is it a leader and a room trading lines back and forth? Every gospel song also has one job at the end: it must land higher than where it started. That climb is the whole point. And repeating one true line until it lands is not lazy – in gospel, that repeat is the craft.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Traditional Gospel / Choir	choir , pastor appreciation , church anniversary , hymn , praise break	A robed choir stacked in rows, one voice leading, the whole room rising on the last chorus.
Contemporary Gospel	testimony	One voice telling you straight what they came through, backed by a full modern band.
Praise & Worship	praise team , worship , thank you lord	One line of thanks, repeated until it fills the whole room.
Urban Gospel / Inspirational R&B & Trap	gospel trap , christian trap , gospel r&b , trap	808s and a rap cadence carrying a real message of faith through a hard night.
Quartet-Style (Southern Soul Gospel)	quartet , southern soul	Four tight voices and one growling lead, straight out of a country church.

Say nothing and you get **Contemporary Gospel**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a gospel song about being thankful

Something warm but empty. Being "thankful" could be anyone, anywhere. With nothing real to hold onto, it reaches for stock church words – blessings, grace, a new day – the same ones every thankful gospel song reaches for.

STRONG PROMPT

Testimony. Two years ago I was sleeping in my car behind the Shell station on Route 9. My sister Denise called me every morning at 6 AM until I finally picked up. Last Sunday I got baptized at Mount Olive Baptist Church. Start the song low, like that car, and let it end with the whole choir on their feet.

Why it sings

- **Testimony** picks the room. It tells the app this is a true account of what someone came through, not just a mood.
- **Denise, Route 9, Mount Olive Baptist Church.** Real people and real places. The song cannot invent these, so it has to use yours.
- **The car is the one picture.** A gospel song is stronger when it returns to a single image instead of just listing thanks.
- **You named the climb.** Asking it to start low and end with the choir standing gives the song its ascent – gospel's whole job.

Try it: swap in your own name, place and turning point. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

A soul song is sung straight to someone real — a lover, a parent, a whole room. It cannot hide behind cool or a joke; every line has to survive being sung to that person's face. The lead voice needs open, simple words it can hold and bend, with a backing group ready to answer it. And when a line repeats, it should land harder each time, not just repeat the same way twice.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Classic Soul	motown , stax	A tight horn section and a voice that means every word, like a dance floor from fifty years ago.
Southern / Deep Soul	deep soul , southern soul	A slow burn — one voice testifying over a groaning organ.
Neo-Soul	neo-soul , neo soul	A loose, jazzy groove under a voice that sounds like it's thinking out loud.

Say nothing and you get **Classic Soul**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a soul song about missing someone

Something pleasant but blank. Missing "someone" could be anyone. With no name or memory to hold onto, it fills the gap with the same longing every soul song reaches for.

STRONG PROMPT

Motown. My parents Ruth and Joe hit forty years married this October, at the same VFW hall where they had their first dance. Dad still spins her in the kitchen every night after the dishes, same three steps he learned back in 1985. I want the horns to come in big right when the chorus hits.

Why it sings

- **Motown** picks the room. One word, and the horn section shows up.
- **Ruth, Joe, the VFW hall, 1985.** Real people and a real date. The song cannot invent these, so it has to use yours.
- **The kitchen dance is the one picture.** A soul song lands harder when it keeps returning to one image instead of naming ten feelings.
- **You told it where the horns land.** Pointing to the chorus gives the band a target instead of just playing loud the whole way through.

Try it: swap in your own names, place and year. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

A jazz song is built like a small building. Two matching sections come first. Then a bridge lifts the feeling somewhere new. Then it comes home again, changed. The singer leans behind the beat and lets words hang late, because that lag is where the feeling lives. And a real solo — a horn or a piano taking a verse — is part of the song, not a break from it.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Vocal Ballad / Torch Song	torch song , standard , crooner , ballad	One voice, close and slow, aching over a piano.
Swing / Uptempo	swing , bebop , scat , uptempo	A big band pushing forward, playful and quick on its feet.
Cool / Late-Night	cool jazz , modal , Chet Baker , Miles	A smoky room after midnight, saying the least it can.

Say nothing and you get **Vocal Ballad / Torch Song**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a jazzy song about a rainy night

Something smooth to have on in the background. A rainy night with no one in it is just weather. It fills the gap with a smoky room and a saxophone — the same picture every rainy-night jazz song reaches for.

STRONG PROMPT

Torch song. I'm closing Rosie's Diner on Fifth Street after thirty-one years, the same booth by the window where my father proposed in 1962. Tomorrow the new owners take the keys. Let the piano sit alone under the first verse, then bring the horns in soft under the last one.

Why it sings

- **Torch song** picks the room. One phrase, and the piano leans in close.
- **Rosie's Diner, Fifth Street, 1962.** Real, specific things. The song cannot invent these, so it has to use yours.
- **The window booth is the one picture.** A jazz song holds together better when it keeps returning to one place instead of describing a whole life.
- **You built the arrangement.** Piano alone, then horns later, gives the bridge — jazz's whole reason for lifting — somewhere real to go.

Try it: swap in your own place, year and what's ending. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

Blues

Recipe 11 of 13

A blues song states the trouble, says it again with a small twist, then answers it in a third line. That is the whole shape, and it has held up for a hundred years. The guitar or harmonica is a second singer, and it needs room to answer back — a verse with no gap for it has gone quiet at the one place blues speaks loudest. And blues only works with one real hard-luck detail from an actual life. Borrowed misery falls flat every time.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Delta / Country Blues	delta blues , country blues , Robert Johnson , crossroads	One voice, one guitar, raw and close to the bone.
Chicago / Electric Blues	chicago blues , electric blues , Muddy Waters , harmonica	A full band and a hard shuffle, loud and citified.
Soul-Blues / Contemporary	soul blues , B.B. King , Bobby Bland , horns	Horns and a stinging guitar, dressed-up heartache sung in full voice.

Say nothing and you get **Delta / Country Blues**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a blues song about hard times

Something that sounds bluesy but says nothing. "Hard times" has no detail in it. So it reaches for the oldest line in the blues book: waking up this morning to trouble it never actually named.

STRONG PROMPT

Chicago blues. I worked the line at Corrigan Steel for twenty-two years before they shut the doors this June. My truck got repossessed on a Tuesday, right in front of the whole block. My wife Loretta still packs my lunch every morning like I've got somewhere to go. Let the harmonica answer every line I sing.

Why it sings

- **Chicago blues** and **harmonica** pick the room. Two words. Now the full band shows up. The harp is ready to answer.
- **Corrigan Steel, twenty-two years, June, Loretta.** Real things a song cannot make up on its own. It has to use yours.
- **The truck on a Tuesday is the one picture.** Blues lands harder on one plain, true fact than on ten lines of general trouble.
- **You gave the harmonica a job.** Asking it to answer every line uses blues' own oldest trick — the instrument as a second voice.

Try it: swap in your own job, place and person. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

A folk song tells something true in plain words, the kind a stranger could follow the first time they hear it. The guitar or fiddle acts like a second voice, answering at the end of each line. And the real detail – the real road, the real name, the actual object in someone’s hand – always beats a fancy line. A folk song reaching for a big poetic phrase when a small plain one would land harder has already lost the plot.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Traditional Folk	folk , protest song , ballad , Woody Guthrie , Pete Seeger	A story or a cause, sung outward to a whole room.
Contemporary Singer-Songwriter	singer-songwriter , confessional , Joni Mitchell , Bon Iver	One voice, close and quiet, like a diary set to fingerpicked guitar.
Folk-Rock / Americana	folk-rock , Americana , indie folk , Mumford , Lumineers	The same true story, swelled up into a stomp a whole band lifts.

Say nothing and you get **Traditional Folk**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

a folk song about leaving home

Something that sounds like a folk song but isn't about anyone. With no real road or person in it, it reaches for old-timey scenery – dusty towns and long-gone trains – instead of your actual life.

STRONG PROMPT

Singer-songwriter. I'm eighteen and leaving Millbrook for the first time tomorrow, driving my grandfather's old Ford to a community college two states over. He taught me three chords on this same porch when I was nine. I want the guitar to sound like it's the only thing in the room.

Why it sings

- **Singer-songwriter** picks the room. One phrase, and the song pulls in close instead of playing to a crowd.
- **Millbrook, the old Ford, age nine.** Real, specific things. The song cannot invent these, so it has to use yours.
- **The porch is the one picture.** A folk song is stronger when it keeps returning to one place instead of describing the whole trip.
- **You named the sound you want.** Asking for just the guitar, alone, matches folk's own rule – words and strings, nothing standing between them.

Try it: swap in your own town, age and object. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

An EDM song is built for a build and a drop, not a story read line by line. The words stay short and repeat, because the vocal is one more instrument in the mix, not the star. The drop itself often has no words at all — just one held note or a chopped sound. But under all that machinery, one real feeling still has to be there, or the drop means nothing when it finally lands.

Pick your room

Say one of these words and you land there on purpose.

ROOM	SAY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
House	house , vocal house , deep house , four-on-the-floor	A warm groove that never really stops moving.
Big-Room / Festival & Progressive	big-room , festival anthem , progressive house , mainstage	One soaring line thrown out to a whole field of people.
Melodic / Future Bass & Chill	future bass , melodic , ODESZA , Illenium	A held, aching note swelling into a wash of sound.

Say nothing and you get **House**. That is a fine room. It is just better when you chose it.

WEAK PROMPT

an EDM song about dancing all night

Something that sounds huge and says nothing. Hands up, the lights, the crowd — that phrase could belong to any track ever made, so the drop soars over nothing real underneath it.

STRONG PROMPT

Melodic. I quit my job at the call center in Tulsa this morning, after four years, and walked out during my lunch break. My best friend Priya is picking me up Friday and we're driving to the coast with no plan. I want the drop to feel like the moment the highway opens up.

Why it sings

- **Melodic** picks the room. One word, and the song reaches for a held, swelling note instead of a hard-edged beat.
- **Tulsa, four years, Priya, Friday.** Real things a song cannot make up on its own. It has to use yours.
- **Walking out at lunch is the one picture.** EDM needs just one true moment to earn the hook repeating again and again.
- **You named what the drop should feel like.** Pointing it at the highway opening up gives the payoff somewhere real to land.

Try it: swap in your own place, person and plan. Keep the shape. The shape is doing most of the work.

CHAPTER 6

When it still isn't right

Six things that go wrong, and the exact fix for each.



You did the five moves and it still came back wrong. That happens. Here is what is usually going on, and the exact fix.

"It sounds like a greeting card."

What happened: the song has feelings in it but no things. Feelings are smooth. Things have edges.

Fix: count the nouns in your prompt that you could photograph. If the answer is under three, add more. Not "her kindness" — her blue Corolla, the crossword she never finished, the good scissors.

"It's the wrong kind of sad."

What happened: you said sad, and sad is enormous. Angry-sad and tender-sad and numb-sad are different songs.

Fix: say what you want the listener to *do*. "I want people to feel relieved." "I want it to sting a bit." That aims it.

"It doesn't sound like the genre."

What happened: you named a genre but not a room, so you landed in that genre's default.

Fix: go to your genre's page in this book and add one of the listed words. That is what those lists are for.

"It's too general, but I don't want to share private stuff."

Totally fair. You do not owe a song your secrets.

Fix: change the details instead of removing them. Move the story to a different city. Change the names. Keep the *shape* of the true thing – the specificity is what works, not the accuracy. A made-up specific beats a true vague every time.

"The chorus is boring."

What happened: I did not know what the one repeated idea should be, so I summarised instead.

Fix: tell me the line, or near enough. "The chorus should be about how she never once locked her door." Even a rough version gives the chorus a spine.

"It's fine. Just... fine."

What happened: it is usually the ending. Some songs stop. Good songs land. A song can be fine all the way through and still feel forgettable if the last line just runs out.

Fix: tell me where to land. "End on the porch light." "Last line should be her name." Give the ending a target and the whole song tightens up.

Still stuck?

Post it in the [Music Review group](#) and ask what is not landing. Real people, real ears, and nobody there is going to be precious about it. It is the fastest way I know to find the one thing you cannot hear yourself.

The cheat sheet

Print this page. Pin it near wherever you write. It is the whole book, minus the talking.

01

One true thing

A detail you could not look up. A name, a street, a smell, the object you kept.

02

Who is talking

Say who "I" is and who they are talking to. Give the lines a direction.

03

The job

Apology? Thank you? First dance? Say what the song has to achieve.

04

The room

Say a style word on purpose. Your genre page lists the ones I listen for.

05

The one picture

Pick one image. Ask me to keep coming back to it.

06

The landing

Tell me where to end. "End on the porch light." Endings make songs feel finished.

The shape: Room. True thing. Who is talking. The job. The picture. Where to land. Six short lines, under a minute to type, and it is the difference between a song about a dad and a song about Roy.

Now go make something

You have the five moves and thirteen recipes. That is genuinely everything I know, and it took you one sitting.

The only part left is the part I cannot do for you. Open the app and type the true thing. The one you almost did not want to write down. That is the one that turns into a song people remember.

SongGhost on the web

songghost.com

Write a song in your browser right now.

SongGhost for iPhone

apps.apple.com/us/app/id6789995320

The same studio, in your pocket.

The Music Review group

www.facebook.com/groups/1059552496761019

Post a song, get real ears on it.

SongGhost on Facebook

www.facebook.com/profile.php?id=61588224848153

News, new genres, and the odd bad joke.

Lyricon

apps.apple.com/us/app/id6779875321

Our other app, for when you want to write the words yourself.

Write one tonight

Free to start, no setup, no keys. songghost.com in your browser, or [SongGhost on iPhone](https://apps.apple.com/us/app/id6789995320).

